Project Completion Report: Widow Vocational Training Program — Cohort 1

Reference: ADA/2022/002 **Organization:** Apoti Development Association (ADA) **Reporting Period:** March 1 – September 30, 2022 **Location:** Bamenda, North-West Region, Cameroon **Report Date:** October 2022

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1. Executive Summary

The Widow Vocational Training Program (Cohort 1) was ADA's first long-term intervention, providing 6 months of vocational training in tailoring and hairdressing to 15 widows in Bamenda who lost their husbands to Anglophone crisis violence. The program exceeded its core targets: 12 of 15 enrolled women graduated with demonstrated competency, all 12 are now earning independent income, and 3 have launched their own small businesses. Participants reported an average 400% increase in income compared to pre-program levels.

Key Results:

Indicator	Target	Achieved
Women enrolled	15	15
Women graduated	12 (80%)	12 (80%)
Graduates earning income	10 (83% of graduates)	12 (100%)
Small businesses launched	2	3
Average income increase	200%	400%
Budget utilization	1,800,000 CFA	1,750,000 CFA (97%)

2. Program Context

Bamenda, the capital of Cameroon's North-West Region, has been severely affected by the Anglophone crisis since 2016. Hundreds of women have been widowed by violence, left without income or marketable skills. Many are sole providers for multiple children. ADA identified 15 women through community networks and church partnerships who met the program criteria: widowed by crisis violence, no stable income, and motivated to commit to a 6-month training program.

This was ADA's first program extending beyond emergency relief, representing a strategic shift toward sustainable, long-term empowerment interventions.

3. Implementation Timeline

Month 1 — March 2022: Orientation and Foundation

- All 15 beneficiaries enrolled and oriented
- Baseline assessments completed (income, skills, needs)
- Training tracks assigned: 9 women chose tailoring, 6 chose hairdressing
- Venue secured and materials procured
- Instructors onboarded (1 master tailor, 1 professional hairdresser)

Month 2 — April 2022: Core Skills Introduction

- Tailoring: Basic stitching, machine operation, fabric cutting
- Hairdressing: Washing techniques, basic braiding, tool maintenance
- All 15 women attending regularly
- First stipend disbursement completed without issues
- Peer support groups formed organically

Month 3 — May 2022: Skill Development

- Tailoring: Pattern reading, garment assembly, alterations
- Hairdressing: Advanced braiding, chemical treatments, styling
- First dropout: 1 woman relocated due to security concerns in her neighborhood
- 14 women continuing; morale high

Month 4 — June 2022: Intermediate Skills and Business Basics

- Tailoring: Complete garment production, quality finishing
- Hairdressing: Salon-standard services, customer interaction
- Business skills module introduced: pricing, record-keeping, customer service
- Second dropout: 1 woman withdrew due to family health emergency (child hospitalization)
- 13 women continuing

Month 5 — July 2022: Advanced Practice

- Tailoring: Complex garments, speed and efficiency, custom orders
- Hairdressing: Full service delivery, time management, product knowledge
- Third dropout: 1 woman unable to continue due to pregnancy complications
- 12 women continuing with strong commitment
- Practice clients introduced for real-world experience

Month 6 — August–September 2022: Mastery and Graduation

- Final competency assessments administered
- All 12 remaining women passed with demonstrated proficiency
- Starter kits assembled and distributed:
  - Tailoring graduates: Sewing machine, fabric starter pack, thread, scissors, measuring tools
  - Hairdressing graduates: Hair dryer, combs, brushes, styling products, initial supply kit
- Graduation ceremony held September 2022 with community leaders, church partners, and beneficiary families
- Post-graduation mentorship plan activated

4. Beneficiary Outcomes

Graduation and Employment

- **12 of 15 women graduated** (80% completion rate)
- **All 12 graduates are earning income** from their acquired skills
- **3 graduates launched independent businesses:**
  - 1 opened a tailoring workshop serving her neighborhood
  - 1 established a home-based hairdressing salon
  - 1 partnered with another graduate to open a combined tailoring/hairdressing shop
- Remaining 9 graduates earn income through freelance work, market stalls, or employment at existing shops

Income Impact

- **Pre-program average income:** Approximately 5,000–10,000 CFA/month (irregular, from petty trading or charity)
- **Post-program average income:** 40,000–60,000 CFA/month
- **Average income increase:** 400%
- All graduates report ability to cover children's school fees, food, and basic household needs independently

Dropout Analysis

Three women (20%) did not complete the program:

#	Reason	Month	Follow-up
1	Security-related relocation	Month 3	Relocated to Douala; connected to partner organization
2	Family health emergency	Month 4	Child recovered; expressed interest in Cohort 2
3	Pregnancy complications	Month 5	Health stabilized; expressed interest in Cohort 2

All three dropouts were due to external circumstances beyond program control. No dropouts were attributed to program dissatisfaction or design failure. Two of the three have expressed interest in joining a future cohort.

5. Success Stories

Marie T. — From Dependence to Business Owner

Marie lost her husband in 2019 and spent three years depending on relatives for survival. She enrolled in the tailoring track with no prior sewing experience. By month 4, she was producing school uniforms. After graduation, she used her starter kit to open a small workshop near a primary school. Within one month, she had regular orders for uniforms and alterations, earning over 50,000 CFA monthly — more than her household had earned in the previous year combined.

Grace N. — Partnership and Growth

Grace and fellow graduate Esther pooled their starter kits and savings to open a combined shop offering both tailoring and hairdressing services. Their complementary skills attract a wider customer base. Three months post-graduation, they employ one apprentice and serve 30+ clients weekly.

Comfort A. — Rebuilding Dignity

Comfort, mother of four, described the program as "giving me back my dignity." Beyond income, she reports improved mental health, community standing, and hope for her children's future. She now earns enough to send all four children to school without assistance.

6. Lessons Learned

1. **Stipends are essential:** The 8,000 CFA monthly stipend removed the primary barrier to attendance (transport and childcare costs). Without it, dropout rates would likely have been much higher.

2. **6 months is the minimum viable duration:** Shorter programs would not achieve competency sufficient for income generation. Some graduates noted they would have benefited from 1–2 additional months.
3. **Peer support drives retention:** Women who formed close bonds with other participants showed higher motivation and attendance. Future cohorts should formalize peer group structures from day one.
4. **Starter kits are critical for immediate income:** Graduates who received kits began earning within days of graduation. Without tools, the gap between training and income would undermine program impact.
5. **Business skills should be integrated earlier:** The business module in month 4 was effective but could have been introduced in month 2 to allow more practice time.
6. **External shocks are the primary dropout risk:** All three dropouts were due to external crises (security, health). Program design cannot fully mitigate these but can offer re-entry pathways.

7. Recommendations for Future Cohorts

1. Increase cohort size to 20 women (accounting for expected 15–20% attrition)
2. Introduce business skills module in month 2
3. Formalize peer support groups with structured weekly sessions
4. Establish a re-entry pathway for women who drop out due to external circumstances
5. Add a 3-month post-graduation mentorship component with monthly check-ins
6. Explore partnerships with microfinance institutions for graduate business loans
7. Document and share graduate success stories for community awareness and future recruitment

8. Financial Summary

- **Approved budget:** 1,800,000 CFA ($3,000 USD)
- **Actual expenditure:** 1,750,000 CFA ($2,917 USD)
- **Variance:** -50,000 CFA (2.8% underspend)
- **Reason for underspend:** Three dropouts reduced stipend disbursements by 3 months of payments (3 × 8,000 × average 3 months = ~72,000 CFA savings, partially offset by other minor overruns)

See detailed financial report: financial.md

9. Conclusion

The Widow Vocational Training Program (Cohort 1) demonstrates that targeted, well-designed vocational interventions can transform the economic prospects of crisis-affected widows. With a modest investment of $2,917, ADA enabled 12 women to achieve economic independence, with ripple effects reaching their children and communities. The 400% average income increase and 100% graduate employment rate validate the program model.

This cohort establishes a replicable framework for ADA's continued work with vulnerable women in the North-West Region and beyond.

Prepared by: ADA Program Team **Date:** October 2022 **Submitted to:** ADA Board of Directors